

A Packing of 14 Four-Spaces in $\mathbb{R}^{13}$

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Abstract

We give 14 4-dimensional subspaces of $\mathbb{R}^{13}$ whose smallest squared chordal distance is at least 2.981903. This cell of the table of best Grassmannian packings has no published value. The best value implied by known packings is 2.966724, obtained by deleting 1 of the 15 four-spaces of the packing found by this search. The value is checked with exact rational arithmetic from integer coordinates. We do not claim it is optimal.

1 Result

Theorem. *There are 14 subspaces of dimension 4 in $\mathbb{R}^{13}$ whose pairwise squared chordal distances $D(a, b) = 4 - \text{tr}(P_a P_b)$ are all at least*

$$D_{\min} = 2.981903 \dots$$

The exact value of $D_{\min}$, a rational number, is given in Appendix A.

2 Context

N. J. A. Sloane's *Table of Best Grassmannian Packings* (last modified 1997), now maintained by Henry Cohn, lists values for some N in the row $m = 13$, $n = 4$. The cell $N = 14$ is blank in Sloane's table, in Sloane's coordinate files and in Cohn's table as checked on October 8, 2026. The best value implied by known packings is 2.966724, obtained by deleting 1 of the 15 four-spaces of the packing found by this search. The Rankin simplex bound for this cell is $4(13 - 4)/13 \cdot 14/13 = 2.982249$, and the value above lies below it.

3 Verification

Each subspace is given by an integer $m \times n$ basis Y (coordinates times 10^{12} , rounded). With $G = Y^\top Y$ the projection is $P = YG^{-1}Y^\top$, so for two subspaces

$$\text{tr}(P_a P_b) = \frac{\text{tr}(\text{adj}(G_a) A \text{adj}(G_b) A^\top)}{\det G_a \det G_b}, \quad A = Y_a^\top Y_b,$$

an exact rational number. No orthonormality is assumed and no floating point is used. Run

`python grassmann/verify.py grassmann/packings/m13n4N14.txt`

in <https://github.com/Ge-limin/math719>.

*Found and checked by Claude, a model released by Anthropic, running on the author's laptop. The author sent the prompts.

4 How it was found

Many random starts of gradient descent on the Grassmannian against a log-sum-exp of the pairwise overlaps, sharpened over time, then a polishing stage (`grassmann/solve.py`); about 63 seconds on one laptop, with about ten such searches running at once.

A Exact value

numerator:

```
425986235760682903568840366576003007511297366677865148332928017820124875
533958494640292886170927547407765819050523406168527836687361729958023562
955958753374536962503728601265802526086153988345
```

denominator:

```
142857142856808454965433857994144873377971429657589270335358375780380879
074402822769331823609220387065355295790770880706935690482408353816494291
223375864754610856640055119586201501260873526134
```

B Coordinates

14 blocks of 13 rows with 4 integers each; divide by 10^{12} . File: `grassmann/packings/m13n4N14.txt`.

```
2377933923 -4309484625 -194372439829 -331422205588 -372135702179 161951776901 -289296146051 -3350276912995012994 287832099704 -112305154977 -281213936898
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